

Big is Beautiful

**Flat panels are hot, and everyone who doesn't have one is not.
Choose yours from one of these...now!**

Michael Browne

For the last year or so most electronics malls have been overflowing with displays of flat panel televisions and everybody flocks to these exhibits. If you happen on any showrooms that stock these large-screen displays you will see several admiring onlookers drooling over the exhibits. The reason for this is simple and steeped in human psyche

— one of our most important senses is the one of sight. A good example of technology having capitalised on this fact are cinema theatres in general. If a person were given the choice between watching a blockbuster release on his television at home or at a cinema hall he would go with the latter nine times out of ten, assuming he isn't a total introvert. This is because a cinema theatre gives any movie a living, breathing feel with a huge screen, and great surround speakers. The thrill of watching anything on a large display just cannot be replicated on a smaller television.

However, many of us do not get time to go to the movies. Work, social commitments and commuting distances are all hindrances. Perhaps this is the reason why

flat screen displays have become so popular. With manufacturers offering advertisement slogans like "bring the movies home" or "your world of entertainment starts here" it's not rocket science to figure out why so many people are throwing out their old 21-inch and 29-inch CRT televisions and buying one of the new breed of televisions; also known as flat panels, flat screen displays, or large screen TVs — these terms are used synonymously by most vendors. The fact is these displays are nothing new in the way of technology. Rather they are based on either of two technologies that have been around for awhile — LCD (Liquid Crystal Display) and Plasma Display.

If you've been a keen spotter of new technological breakthroughs and keep a close watch on market prices, you will note that the price of LCD monitors have fallen drastically. There was a time five years back when 22-inch monitors were unheard of and when these displays appeared they were priced at near the Rs. 35,000 mark. Today one can buy a 22-inch LCD monitor for less than Rs. 12,000 and the prices of larger displays have percolated into the lower rungs of the market. The reasons for this are binary — technological advances leading to sharp declines in costs of production and of course mass adoption, which itself is often a function of the former. Just as the prices of LCD monitors have fallen, the falling costs and technological breakthroughs made it possible and feasible for manufacturers to explore